

TOP 5 cities

WHERE MEN APPROVE OF ADULTERY

Hyderabad: 72

Delhi: 62

Ludhiana: 61

Ahmedabad: 50

Mumbai: 42

sexual expression. I received the survey figures at about the same time that I read in a lifestyle article in *Anandabazar Patrika* of a trio who had opted to be a married unit: two sisters chose to marry the same man (one of them legally) in a convenient sexual, labour and residential arrangement. A few days later, the paper reported the abandonment of an AIDS-afflicted woman by her in-laws, who chose instead to care for her husband with AIDS—even though he appeared to have been the primary carrier, she was depicted as sexually promiscuous and contaminated. It is through these daily stories that we notice non-monogamy and sexual diversity pervading social life. And yet, as the AIDS narrative illustrates, sexual power relations may not be favourable to women, and they may bear the

rency in these negotiations. Allegations against wives on grounds of pre-marital involvement or ongoing relationships is routine (as Flavia Agnes also points out in the 2007 INDIA TODAY article accompanying the surveys), alongside allegations that wives are not behaving appropriately in the joint family, that they are domestically incompetent, or that they have unreported sources of income. Wives often allege that husbands are sexually or emotionally involved (with family members or neighbours) as well, but they typically seek the right to demand conjugal space and affection as a condition of returning to the marriage.

However, economic survival can be the bottom line, making marital exclusivity a moot point. There were numerous cases of known bigamy in the courts which Hindu wives were loath to prosecute because they could not afford for their maintenance money to be cut off if husbands were jailed. Family court judges, too, would ignore bigamy questions and focus on ensuring maintenance to wives and children as the prime goal. The economic perils of bigamy were illustrated in the case of a Muslim woman, a younger wife who neither wanted to live in the household with the first wife and her children and grandchildren, nor liked the solitary rental room where she saw her husband once a week, nor could she live with her family who exploited her labour. Most poignantly, a destitute and long-divorced woman in court seeking some of her ex-husband's pension as maintenance, had requested for her basic survival that he let her live in his house again and help with housework as an extra domestic worker might, knowing that his current wife's swollen feet did not allow her to do housework and that he and his adult sons were managing with difficulty. He refused.

Norms of conjugality may have shifted in the 20th century to idealise the married couple, who are to be each others' sole sources of sex, romance and companionship. But neither marriage nor sexual behaviour has conformed comfortably to monogamy.

The author is an Associate Professor of Gender and Women's Studies at the University of Kentucky.

For past surveys, interactive graphics visit:
www.indiatoday.in/sexsurvey08



Model's outfit by MANGO

WHERE WOMEN APPROVE OF ADULTERY

Chennai: 18

Ludhiana: 17

Bangalore: 12

Patna: 10

Mumbai: 9

Lucknow: 9

All figures in per cent

economic and social brunt of sexual diversity whether they have made that choice or not.

My research on family courts and family violence in Kolkata over the last few years has only confirmed my conviction of the primacy of marriage as an economic arrangement in the post-colonial state. The majority of cases deal with much lower socio-economic strata than the survey subjects represent, and the economic security promised by marriage is usually a woman's sole means of sustenance.

Economic anxieties include the affordability of urban residential space, sharing resources and power in the extended household, financial responsibility of wives' families and wives' limited incomes. Marital fidelity is a cur-